

By now, we've established that the job market is rough and youth unemployment is at an all-time high. Is it any coincidence that an increasing number of students are opting to pursue graduate degrees? Master's and PhD programs are receiving an epic deluge of applications, and for good reason: nobody wants to face the real world.

If you're considering a career in academia, I urge you to think pragmatically. Ask yourself the following question: What are your chances of getting a job later? A friend of ours has a son who is currently looking at PhD programs in philosophy. He came to the cottage a few months ago, and I asked him how many job openings he thought there would be for professors of philosophy once he completed his dissertation.

"Next to nil," he said. "It's one of the hardest departments to get placement."

I couldn't believe it. This 22-year-old kid was about to spend the next decade of his life reading and writing about dead guys, all so he could get a fancy piece of paper *that would never translate into a paying job*. What was he thinking? Nobody ever gives up a tenured position in a university philosophy department, which means there's no room for the up-and-comers.

There is a big difference between a Doctor of Medicine and a Doctor of Philosophy. Both degrees require a tremendous amount of time and effort, but one invariably leads to some form of employment; the other does not. I'm not saying a PhD in philosophy isn't useful in other ways; I'm just saying there aren't a lot of opportunities to monetize it.

As an author, I work with a lot of talented people in publishing. Few of them have MFAs (Master of Fine Arts degrees). These people are highly successful liberal arts students who've creatively figured out how to monetize their skills. They took an entrepreneurial approach. Instead of going the route of a master's or PhD, they decided to "make their own master's." They took specific courses, enrolled in online classes, handpicked the mentors they wanted to study with at conferences and workshops, and formed their own writing groups (for free). In other words, they amassed experience